Saryarqa Go

ZERTTEX Hackathon 2026, Final (Stage 2). Case 1: Technology Product

Team: _____

Saryarqa Routes wants 30% of its travelers to come from abroad within 24 months, but today about 96% of its 3,400 travelers are from Kazakhstan (case data). We propose Saryarqa Go, a booking platform in English and Chinese for independent travelers from China. It shows exactly what each tour includes, lets travelers meet their guide before paying, and accepts foreign cards. The first version can be built in 12 weeks, with all year-1 costs within 8,000,000 KZT. Clickable prototype: https://diawx-6669.github.io/ZERttex/

1. Problem and market

Target market: independent travelers from mainland China

According to the Ministry of Tourism and Sports, about 655,000 people from China visited Kazakhstan in 2024, 78% more than in 2023 [1][2]. Since November 2023 the two countries have a visa-free regime: up to 30 days per visit and up to 90 days in any 180 days [1]. In 2024 China was the largest source of tourists outside the neighbouring countries [3]. Overall, Kazakhstan counted 15.3 million foreign visitors for tourism in 2024 [3] and 15.7 million in the first nine months of 2025 [5]. An analyst estimate gives 241,700 Chinese visitors in 2025 [4], but it is counted in a different way from the Ministry figure, so we do not compare the two. The tours fit what independent travelers look for: nature and photography (Charyn, Kolsai, Burabay) and Silk Road history (Turkestan). This last point is our own judgement.

What stops them from booking today

The company sells through Instagram messages, WhatsApp and phone calls, takes payment by Kaspi transfer or cash, and has a one-page website in Russian (case data). Foreign guests named four problems:

What guests said (case data)	**When the booking fails**	**Why it happens now**
"It is unclear how to book."	Before the first message	Sales only through chats; Russian-only website
"I am not sure the company is trustworthy."	Before sending money abroad	Nothing proves the company is real
"My foreign card does not work."	At the payment	Only Kaspi transfer or cash
"I do not know what is included."	Before deciding	No clear list of what the price covers

About 4% of 3,400 travelers (roughly 136) are foreign today. If the company keeps its 3,264 local travelers, 30% foreign means about 4,663 travelers in total and about 1,399 foreigners. So the company needs around 1,263 additional foreign travelers per year, about 105 per month.

2. Existing solutions

Big booking platforms already sell tours to this region. Trip.com, for example, lists one-day tours from Almaty to Charyn Canyon, Kolsai Lake and Lake Kaindy [8]. These platforms solve the payment problem and work in many languages. But for Saryarqa Routes they have three weak points. First, they take a large commission: GetYourGuide says it charges suppliers 20-30% depending on the country [9], which is most of a small company's margin. Second, the tour becomes one listing among many similar day trips, so the company cannot show its own guides or build trust in its brand. Third, the customer relationship belongs to the platform, so it is hard to sell longer trips or get repeat and referral customers.

The company's current tools (Instagram, WhatsApp, phone) keep the relationship but fail all four complaints above. Saryarqa Go keeps the direct relationship and the full margin, and adds what the platforms do not: the "not yet confirmed" list, meeting the guide before paying, and help in Chinese. Later we can still list on Trip.com as an extra channel.

3. Our product

Saryarqa Go is a web platform (also usable as a mobile app) built around one path: discover, plan, check, book, travel and share. The last step brings new travelers back to the first. It has five main features:

1. **Clear tour pages in English and Chinese.** Every tour shows four lists: included, optional extras, not included, and not yet confirmed (for example park fees or the 4x4 transfer at Kaindy). The company confirms the last list in writing before the trip.
2. **Booking and payment in three steps.** Tour and date, lead traveler (no passport needed), payment. Foreign cards are paid on the payment provider's own page; Alipay and WeChat Pay are added after the providers approve us. Prices are in KZT with CNY or USD next to them.
3. **Trust page.** A short video from each guide, a 5-minute video call before paying, refund rules, and an honest list of which company documents are already shown and which are still coming.
4. **Chat assistant in English and Chinese.** It answers only from checked tour information and passes anything it is not sure about (dates, discounts) to a manager.
5. **Trip page and postcard.** Daily check-ins, optional updates for family at home, free rescheduling if a mountain road is closed, and a postcard for Xiaohongshu and WeChat Moments with a link for friends.

Technology: React and TypeScript web app, a database with an admin page for managers, and the payment provider's hosted payment page, so card data never touches our servers. **What makes it unique:** it is honest about what is still unknown, it lets the traveler meet the person who will guide them, and every shared trip brings a new customer at almost no cost.

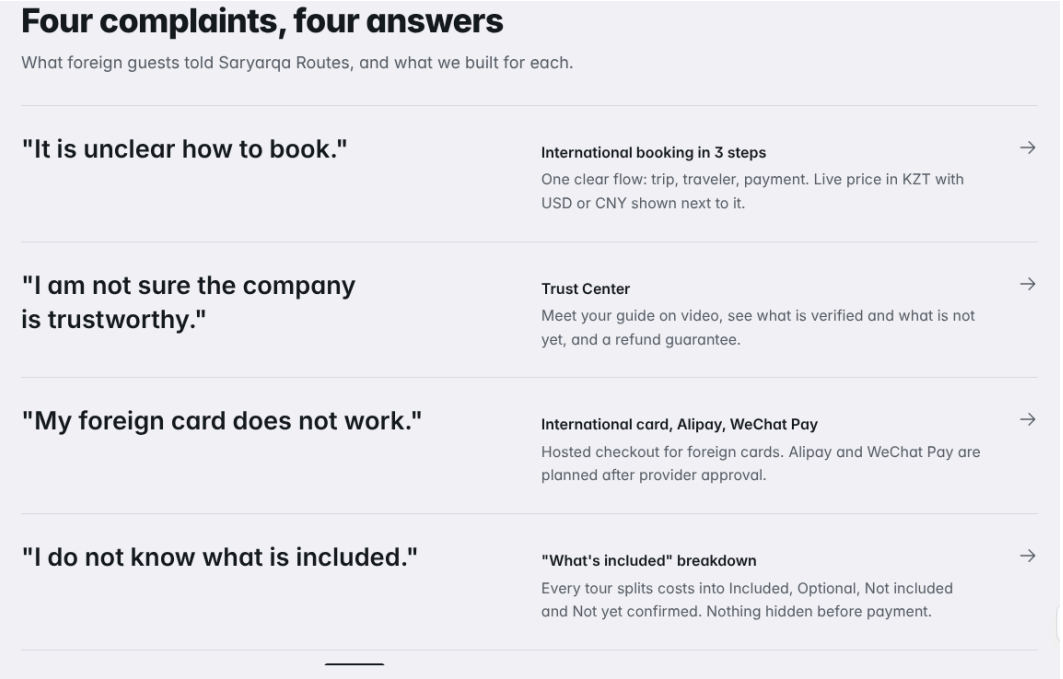


Figure 1. Our clickable prototype: each complaint from the case is linked to a feature.

4. MVP and implementation

The MVP (paid from the 8,000,000 KZT budget) includes the tour pages in English and Chinese with the inclusion lists, booking in three steps with a foreign card on the provider's page, the trust page, a chat that answers only from checked tour data and hands off to a manager, the postcard with a referral QR code, and a manager inbox for staff. Phase 2 comes later: the trip builder, weather and road rescheduling, family updates, the offline audio guide, live Alipay and WeChat Pay, and listing on Trip.com.

Weeks	What we do	We know it is done when
1-2	Interviews and research; apply to payment providers	At least 10 interviews with Chinese travelers; applications sent
3-4	Design and tour pages in English and Chinese	4 tour pages checked by 3 or more target users
5-7	Booking, inclusion lists, chat, trust page	A full test booking works in the payment test mode
8-9	Real payment page, manager inbox, postcard QR	Staff make a first real test payment
10-11	Usability tests and payment checks	5-8 test sessions with no blocking problems left
12	Pilot with real travelers	Pilot results collected

Team: a hired designer, two developers and a Chinese translator, with one person from Saryarqa Routes as product owner (our proposal). **How we test it:** 5-8 usability sessions with Chinese-speaking travelers, then a pilot where we measure how many people who start

a booking finish it, how often the chat has to hand off to a manager, and how many postcards lead to new bookings. We already built a working clickable prototype of the whole path (payments in it are simulated): https://diawx-6669.github.io/ZERttex/

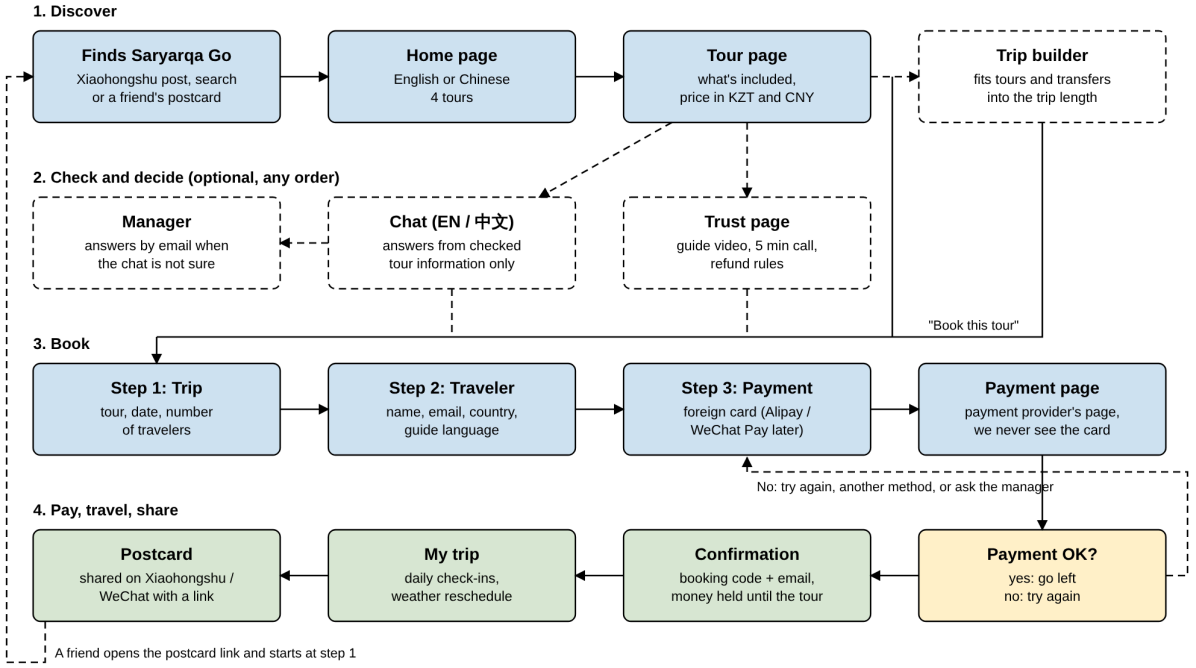


Figure 2. User flow from search to payment. Dashed boxes are optional.

5. Costs, payback and impact

Item	Type	KZT
Design & development of MVP	one-time	3,300,000
Localization EN / 中文 + guide videos	one-time	800,000
Payment integration & testing	one-time	700,000
AI concierge setup & testing	one-time	300,000
Marketing & acquisition (Xiaohongshu content, pilot)	recurring	1,700,000
Hosting + AI usage	recurring	500,000
Support & pilot	recurring	300,000
Reserve	reserve	400,000
Total year 1 (Stage 2 limit 8,000,000)		**8,000,000**

From year 2 running costs are 250,000 KZT per month (our estimate). **How it earns money:** the company keeps its margin on every additional foreign traveler. We assume 30% of the 44,000 KZT average price (case data) is left after guides, transport, hotels and payment

fees, so 13,200 KZT per traveler (our assumption). We do not count extras, longer trips or referrals, so the result is careful. Travelers start in month 4 and grow step by step to 1,263 per year by month 24.

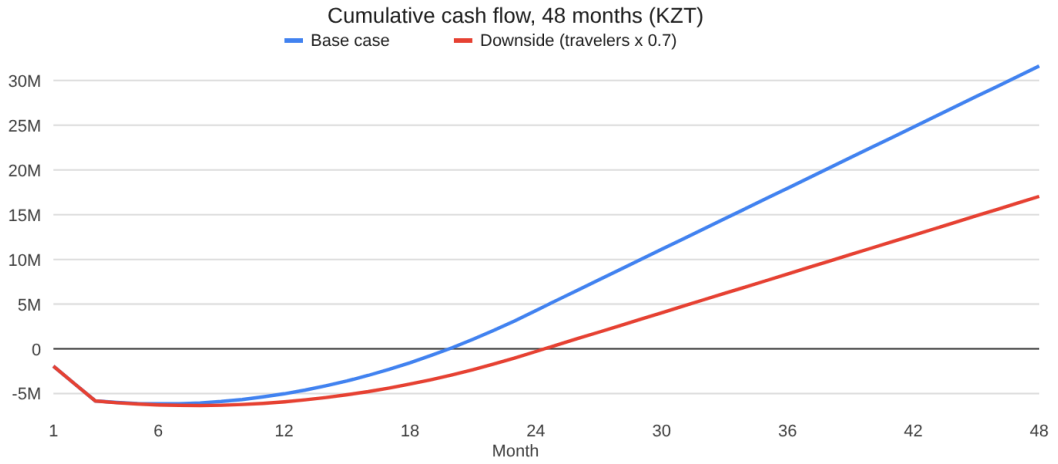


Figure 3. Cumulative cash flow. Red line: results 30% worse than planned.

Result	**Base case**	**30% worse**
Lowest point	-6.2M	-6.3M
Payback month	**20**	**25**
Total after 48 months	31.6M	17.0M
Payback if the margin is 20% / 40%	month 26 / 17	month 34 / month 21

If results are 30% worse, the project still pays back, but in month 25 instead of 20. In that case we would move marketing to free channels (postcards, our own Xiaohongshu posts), delay paid ads and keep running costs at the minimum. **Scalability:** the same platform can add Korean or English-speaking markets with new translations, and new tours can be added by managers without developers.

Impact. The company gets a second source of income next to local customers and stops losing foreign guests at the payment step. Travelers get clear prices, their own payment method and a guide they have already met. For Kazakhstan, every good trip shared on Chinese social media is free advertising, and it brings tourists to regions outside Almaty and Astana.

Biggest risks	What we do about it
Alipay or WeChat Pay approval is slow	Start with foreign cards; apply in week 1; a manager can help with payment
The chat gives a wrong answer	Only checked information; it says "I don't know" and passes to a person
Not enough demand from China	Interviews first; small pilot; test free posts before paid ads
Data privacy and payments	No passport and no card data stored; legal check; family sharing off by default
Guides' Chinese is weak	Test guides; interpreters; Chinese audio guide as backup

6. Conclusion

Foreign travelers do not book Saryarqa Routes because they cannot see what is included, cannot pay with their card and cannot check the company. Saryarqa Go fixes all four problems in one product, starting with Chinese travelers who can already visit without a visa. It fits the 8,000,000 KZT limit and pays back in month 20, or month 25 if results are 30% worse. Our next steps: interview at least 10 Chinese travelers, check the real margin with the company, and apply to payment providers in the first week.